SALES & MARKETING
Complete Domain Learning Guide

10 modules • Practical examples • Calculations • Checkpoints • Practice assessment

Learn to understand customers, position products, select channels, plan campaigns, measure performance, manage sales opportunities, improve retention and market ethically.

Practice assessment: 20 questions
Suggested pass target: 14/20 (70%)

How to use this guide

Read the modules in order and focus on applying the ideas to short scenarios. Marketing decisions should start with a customer problem, a clearly defined audience and a measurable objective. Sales and marketing work together, but they have different immediate responsibilities.

Core principle: Choose a tactic because it fits the customer, objective and evidence—not because a channel or trend is popular.

1. Marketing Foundations

Marketing mix: the 4 Ps

Product is the solution and experience offered; Price is what the customer gives up and how value is captured; Place is how the offer is distributed and accessed; Promotion is how people learn about and respond to it. Modern marketing also considers service, customer experience, data and relationships. Example: a student-planner app may offer a free basic plan, a paid premium tier, app-store distribution and campus ambassador promotion.

Marketing, branding and sales

Marketing researches customer needs, creates demand and builds a path to purchase. Branding shapes the associations and expectations people hold about the organisation. Sales helps an interested prospect evaluate, decide and buy. They overlap but are not interchangeable: a strong brand may improve trust, marketing can create qualified demand, and sales can convert a suitable opportunity.

Positioning

Positioning is the place an offer occupies in the customer's mind relative to alternatives. Effective positioning identifies a specific audience, relevant need, distinctive benefit and reason to believe. 'The fastest tool for every person' is vague; 'a lightweight budgeting app for first-job earners who want to track spending in under five minutes a day' is more concrete.

Demand generation

Demand generation builds awareness and interest that may later produce qualified buyers. It can include useful educational content, events, search, social campaigns, email and partner activity. Measure more than views: examine engaged visitors, qualified leads, opportunities and eventual revenue where appropriate.

Start with the problem

Before launching a campaign, state who has the problem, when it occurs, what people do today, why alternatives are inadequate and what evidence suggests they would switch. A feature is not automatically a customer benefit; translate 'automated reminders' into 'fewer missed deadlines'.

Scenario

A startup advertises dozens of features, but users do not understand why they need the product. The likely fix is not simply more advertising. Research the target customer's pain point, clarify positioning and lead with one credible benefit.

Module checkpoint
A company has many features but customers do not understand the value. What should it clarify first?

Answer: The customer problem, target audience and positioning before increasing promotion.

2. Audience Research & Personas

Buyer persona

A buyer persona is a research-based profile of a representative customer: goals, context, behaviours, constraints, objections and decision criteria. Use interviews, surveys, analytics, support tickets and sales conversations. Separate observed evidence from assumptions; do not invent detailed personality traits based on stereotypes.

Customer journey

A journey often includes awareness, consideration, evaluation, purchase, onboarding, use, renewal and advocacy. At each stage identify the customer's question, touchpoint, friction and desired next step. The journey is not always linear: people revisit options or ask others for advice.

Pain point

A pain point is a specific frustration, risk, cost or unmet need. ‘Wants convenience’ is broad; ‘spends 40 minutes every week reconciling expenses across three spreadsheets’ is actionable. Prioritise pains by severity, frequency, willingness to pay and fit with the product.

Buying trigger

A buying trigger is an event that changes passive interest into active search, such as a new job, a compliance deadline, a system failure or a rapid increase in workload. Content that explains the trigger and next steps can be more effective than generic product promotion.

Research workflow

Define the decision to inform, recruit relevant participants, ask neutral questions about past behaviour, code recurring themes and test whether the findings generalise. Ask ‘Tell me about the last time you solved this’ rather than ‘Would you buy our amazing product?’

Scenario

A persona says ‘busy manager’ but is based only on a team’s guesses. Improve it by interviewing actual buyers, reviewing search queries and analysing support requests, then documenting evidence, uncertainties and objections.

Module checkpoint
What is the difference between a pain point and a buying trigger?

Answer: A pain point is the ongoing frustration; a buying trigger is the event that prompts active search.

3. Segmentation, Targeting & Positioning

Segmentation

Segmentation divides a market into groups with meaningful differences. B2C variables can include geography, demographics, needs, behaviour and usage. B2B segmentation may use industry, company size, workflow, technology, buying authority and regulatory context. Good segments are sufficiently distinct, measurable, reachable and actionable.

Targeting

Targeting selects which segments to serve. Assess segment size and growth, customer need, competitive intensity, reachability, expected economics and organisational capability. A small segment with urgent need and low competition may be more attractive than a huge segment the business cannot serve well.

Differentiation

Differentiation is the reason a customer should choose one option over the closest alternative. It may involve performance, simplicity, service, reliability, price, integration or trust. A difference matters only if the target audience values it and the organisation can deliver it credibly.

Positioning statement

A useful template is: ‘For [target audience] who [need], [product] is a [category] that [primary benefit], because [reason to believe].’ Example: ‘For small clinics that lose time scheduling visits, QueueCare is an appointment tool that reduces manual coordination through automated reminders and a shared calendar.’ The claim should be testable rather than impossible to disprove.

Evaluate the segment

A practical scorecard rates segments for need intensity, size, growth, acquisition cost, competition, fit and ability to serve. Use evidence and weights that reflect strategy; do not pretend an approximate score is objective truth.

Scenario

A low-cost product targets both premium enterprise buyers and price-sensitive individuals with the same message. The audiences have different needs and buying processes, so separate targeting and positioning may be required.

Module checkpoint
What does targeting mean?

Answer: Selecting the market segments the organisation will serve based on attractiveness and ability to win.

4. Digital Channels

Owned, paid and earned media

Owned media includes a website, app, blog and opted-in email list. Paid media includes search ads, social ads, display and sponsorships. Earned media includes independent press coverage, reviews, recommendations and word of mouth. Owned gives control, paid can scale reach quickly, and earned may create credibility but is less controllable.

Match channel to funnel stage

Search often captures existing intent; educational content can build awareness and consideration; retargeting can remind eligible visitors; email can nurture opted-in leads or support customers. Channel choice should reflect audience behaviour, objective, creative format, budget and measurement quality.

Reach, impressions and frequency

Reach is the estimated number of distinct people exposed. Impressions are total exposures, so one person may create multiple impressions. Frequency = impressions ÷ reach. High frequency can reinforce a message but can also cause fatigue.

Click-through rate

CTR = clicks ÷ impressions × 100%. If an ad receives 240 clicks from 12,000 impressions, CTR = 2%. CTR indicates response to an ad, not necessarily qualified traffic or sales. A clickbait message may have high CTR but poor downstream conversion.

Cost metrics

CPC = ad spend ÷ clicks. CPM = ad spend ÷ impressions × 1,000. If ■6,000 generates 300 clicks, CPC is ■20. If ■6,000 buys 200,000 impressions, CPM is ■30. Compare like-for-like audiences, objectives and periods.

Scenario

A campaign needs to reach people already searching for a solution. Search ads may capture intent; a broad awareness video may be useful for a different objective but should not be judged only by immediate sales.

Module checkpoint
An ad gets 500 clicks from 25,000 impressions. What is CTR?

Answer: 500 ÷ 25,000 × 100% = 2%.

5. Content & Creative

Message hierarchy

Put the most important customer benefit first, followed by supporting benefits and evidence, then detail and a clear next step. The audience should understand the main point even if they skim. One asset can adapt to different formats, but the central promise should remain consistent.

Call to action (CTA)

A CTA tells the audience what to do next: ‘Book a demo’, ‘Compare plans’ or ‘Download the checklist’. Match the CTA to intent. A person who has just discovered a brand may need a low-commitment next step rather than ‘Buy now’.

Creative brief

A brief should include objective, audience, insight or pain point, key message, proof points, tone, deliverables, formats, constraints, deadline, approver and success metric. State what must be included and what is out of scope.

Tone of voice

Tone of voice is the consistent personality and register used in communication. A financial service may favour clarity and reassurance; a youth-focused learning app may sound energetic. Tone can adapt by context while remaining recognisably the same brand.

Adapt content across formats

A detailed blog can become a short social post, email subject line, infographic and video script. Preserve the main idea and evidence while changing length and structure. Do not remove qualifications that are necessary for the claim to remain truthful.

Scenario

A designer receives only ‘make it attractive’. A better brief names the target audience, problem, key benefit, proof, CTA, dimensions, deadline and measurement criteria.

Module checkpoint
What should a creative brief specify?

Answer: Objective, audience, insight, key message, proof, tone, deliverables, constraints, deadline and success metric.

6. Campaign Planning

Campaign objective

Choose one primary measurable outcome for a defined period. Use a SMART-style objective: specific, measurable, achievable, relevant and time-bound. Example: ‘Generate 150 qualified demo requests from small retailers during November at an average cost below ■1,000 per qualified request.’ Awareness goals need awareness metrics; sales goals need sales metrics.

Budget allocation

Allocate spend based on objective, audience reach, expected performance, test needs and channel role. Reserve some budget for experiments, but set a stopping rule. Do not split budget equally simply for convenience.

Flighting and pacing

Flighting concentrates activity into bursts, useful for launches or seasonal demand. Always-on activity runs continuously, useful for capturing ongoing intent. Pacing monitors spend over time so the budget is not exhausted too early or left unused.

Dependencies and critical path

A dependency is a task that must finish before another begins. For example, legal approval may be required before creative production is final; landing-page tracking must work before paid traffic begins. The critical path is the sequence of dependent tasks that determines the earliest possible completion date.

Launch calendar

A campaign calendar lists tasks, owners, due dates, approvals, dependencies, channels, deliverables and measurement checkpoints. Include contingency time for review, tracking failures and last-minute changes.

Worked budget example

A ■1,00,000 test budget might allocate ■40,000 to high-intent search, ■25,000 to social prospecting, ■15,000 to content production and ■20,000 to controlled experiments. This is an illustrative allocation, not a universal formula; revise it based on audience evidence and performance.

Module checkpoint
A campaign must reach a seasonal audience in a concentrated burst. Which scheduling approach may fit?

Answer: Flighting, with pacing and dependencies planned.

7. Measurement & Analytics

Conversion rate

Conversion rate = conversions ÷ eligible visitors or users × 100%. If 80 of 2,000 landing-page visitors sign up, the rate is 4%. Always define the denominator and conversion event; ‘conversion rate’ can mean different things at different funnel steps.

Read the funnel

Track progression through stages such as impressions → clicks → landing-page visits → leads → qualified leads → opportunities → sales. Find where the largest meaningful drop occurs, then investigate audience fit, message, page experience, pricing, trust and follow-up. A low rate is a clue, not an explanation.

Attribution

Attribution assigns credit to touchpoints preceding a conversion. Last-click gives credit to the final click; first-touch credits discovery; multi-touch models distribute credit. Each has limitations because customer journeys are complex and data may be incomplete. Attribution is not the same as proving causation.

Return on ad spend (ROAS)

ROAS = revenue attributed to ads ÷ ad spend. ■3,00,000 attributed revenue from ■60,000 ad spend gives 5× ROAS. ROAS is not profit: product costs, discounts, fulfilment, returns and overhead may still make the campaign unprofitable.

Guardrail metrics

Guardrails reveal whether improving the primary metric causes harm elsewhere. Examples include unsubscribe rate, refund rate, complaint rate, lead quality, margin, privacy complaints or customer retention. A campaign that raises sign-ups but doubles fraudulent accounts has not necessarily improved business outcomes.

Experimentation

Test one major variable at a time where possible, define the hypothesis and success metric before launch, and avoid stopping early just because results temporarily look good. Check sample size, seasonality, audience differences and whether the change is practically meaningful.

> **Module checkpoint**
> A landing page gets 80 sign-ups from 2,000 visitors. Conversion rate?

Answer: 80 ÷ 2,000 × 100% = 4%.

8. Sales Fundamentals

Sales pipeline

A pipeline maps opportunities through defined stages, such as lead, qualified, discovery, proposal, negotiation and closed won/lost. Each stage needs entry and exit criteria. A deal should not move forward merely because a salesperson feels optimistic.

Lead qualification

Qualification checks whether the prospect has a real need, authority or access to decision-makers, budget or a path to funding, and a plausible timeline. Frameworks such as BANT can help structure questions, but should not become a rigid checklist that ignores context.

Discovery conversation

Ask open questions about current process, impact of the problem, desired outcome, constraints and decision process. Listen carefully and summarise what you heard before pitching. Qualification is about mutual fit, not pressuring every lead into a purchase.

Objection handling

Clarify the concern before responding. If a prospect says ‘too expensive’, ask what they are comparing it with or which outcome is not yet worth the price. Then respond with relevant evidence, options or a clear admission that the fit may not be right. Discounting immediately can damage margin and trust.

Win rate

Win rate = won qualified opportunities ÷ total qualified opportunities closed in the period × 100%, if that definition is used consistently. For 18 wins from 60 closed qualified opportunities, win rate = 30%. Do not mix open deals into a closed-opportunity denominator without stating the method.

Scenario

A prospect says the solution is expensive. Instead of immediately reducing price, the salesperson explores expected value, budget constraints, alternatives and whether a smaller package can solve the main problem.

> **Module checkpoint**
> A prospect says the product is too expensive. What is the first step?

Answer: Clarify the concern and the comparison before proposing a response or discount.

9. Retention & Growth

Retention and churn

Retention is the proportion of a defined customer group that remains active over a period. Churn is the loss of customers or subscribers. For a simple customer-count measure: retention = (starting customers – customers lost) ÷ starting customers × 100%, when new customers are excluded from the calculation.

Worked retention example

A service starts the month with 500 customers and loses 35 of them. Customer churn = 35 ÷ 500 × 100% = 7%; retention of the starting cohort is 93%. If new customers join during the month, do not let them hide losses in the original cohort.

Onboarding

Good onboarding helps customers reach a first meaningful success quickly. Explain the next step, remove setup friction, offer guidance at the right moment and identify users who get stuck. Measure time to first value, activation and early retention.

Referral loop and loyalty

A referral loop makes it easy for satisfied customers to invite others, often with a transparent incentive. Loyalty programmes reward repeated value or behaviour. Design rewards carefully so they do not encourage fraud, low-quality acquisition or uneconomic discounts.

Cohort analysis

A cohort is a group sharing a starting event or period, such as customers acquired in January. Track the same group over time to compare retention, repeat purchases or revenue. Cohort analysis avoids mixing older loyal customers with newly acquired customers and drawing misleading conclusions.

Scenario

Overall monthly active users are stable, but recent customer cohorts disappear after two weeks. Investigate onboarding and early value rather than assuming the business has healthy retention.

Module checkpoint
A service starts with 500 customers and loses 35. Monthly churn?

Answer: 35 ÷ 500 × 100% = 7%, excluding the effect of new customers.

10. Ethics & Compliance in Marketing

Substantiation

Substantiation means having evidence that supports a factual claim before publishing it. Claims about performance, savings, health, environmental impact or market leadership require suitable evidence and careful wording. A disclaimer does not automatically fix a misleading headline.

Consent and data minimisation

Collect and use personal data lawfully, transparently and for defined purposes. Obtain valid consent where required, respect opt-outs and applicable privacy rules, limit collection to what is needed, secure data and define retention periods. Rules vary by jurisdiction and context; consult current legal guidance for actual campaigns.

Disclosure

Clearly disclose paid partnerships, sponsorships, affiliate links or other material commercial relationships so audiences can judge the message in context. Disclosures should be noticeable, understandable and placed where people will see them—not hidden in a long block of hashtags.

Dark patterns

Dark patterns are interface choices that manipulate users into actions they may not knowingly choose, such as hidden cancellation, preselected paid add-ons, confusing opt-outs or false urgency. Design for informed, reversible and understandable choices.

Truthful pricing and scarcity

Show material fees, conditions, limitations and renewal terms clearly. Do not invent countdowns, fake scarcity or unsupported testimonials. Use real evidence and keep claims consistent across ads, landing pages and sales conversations.

Scenario

An email campaign uses a purchased list without checking permission and makes unsubscribing difficult. This creates privacy, compliance and trust risks. Use an appropriate permission basis, explain why recipients are contacted and provide a clear opt-out.

> **Module checkpoint**
> Why disclose an influencer's paid partnership?

Answer: So the audience can understand the commercial relationship and assess the message fairly.

Cross-module worked calculations

1. Channel metrics

A paid campaign spends ■12,000 and receives 600 clicks from 30,000 impressions. CTR = 600 ÷ 30,000 × 100% = 2%. CPC = ■12,000 ÷ 600 = ■20. CPM = ■12,000 ÷ 30,000 × 1,000 = ■400. These measures describe exposure and response; they do not prove sales or profit.

2. Funnel diagnosis

A campaign has 10,000 impressions, 400 clicks, 200 landing-page sessions and 10 purchases. CTR = 4%; click-to-session rate = 50%; session-to-purchase conversion = 5%. The loss between clicks and sessions may indicate slow loading or tracking differences. Check the data and user experience before assuming the ad message is the cause.

3. ROAS versus profit

If ads cost ■50,000 and attributed revenue is ■2,00,000, ROAS = 4×. If product, delivery, returns and other variable costs total ■1,70,000, the campaign's contribution before other overhead is only ■30,000, not ■1,50,000. Revenue is not the same as profit.

4. Retention

A cohort begins with 800 customers; 720 remain active after a month. Cohort retention = 720 ÷ 800 × 100% = 90%. If 100 new customers joined during that month, they should not be added to the original cohort when calculating that cohort's retention.

Practice assessment — 20 questions

Choose one best answer for each question. The answer key includes explanations. A score of 14/20 equals 70%.

1. What should marketing clarify before launching a campaign?

A. Which animation to use

B. The customer problem and target audience

C. The largest possible budget

D. The number of hashtags

2. Branding is best described as:

A. Only closing deals

B. The associations and expectations customers hold about an organisation

C. A sales pipeline stage

D. A media cost metric

3. A buying trigger is:

A. A long-term frustration only

B. An event that prompts active search for a solution

C. A brand colour

D. An ad impression

4. Targeting means:

A. Selecting which segments to serve

B. Writing every possible message

C. Assigning revenue to touchpoints

D. Calculating churn

5. Which is earned media?

A. A company website

B. A paid search ad

C. Independent press coverage

D. An internal email

6. An ad receives 300 clicks from 15,000 impressions. CTR is:

A. 0.5%

B. 2%

C. 5%

D. 20%

7. A call to action should:

A. Hide the next step

B. Tell the audience what to do next

C. Replace the main benefit

D. Guarantee a sale

8. A creative brief is used to:

A. Define audience, message, constraints and success criteria

B. Replace customer research

C. Guarantee viral reach

D. Calculate Scope 1 emissions

9. Flighting refers to:

A. Concentrating campaign activity into planned bursts

B. Assigning a lead to sales

C. Customer churn

D. Writing a persona

10. A dependency in a campaign plan is:

A. A task that must finish before another can start

B. A social media follower

C. A revenue metric

D. A brand promise

11. A page converts 120 visitors from 3,000 visitors. Conversion rate is:

A. 2%

B. 4%

C. 8%

D. 25%

12. ROAS is calculated as:

A. Ad spend ÷ revenue

B. Revenue attributed to ads ÷ ad spend

C. Profit ÷ customers

D. Clicks ÷ impressions

13. A guardrail metric is used to:

A. Ensure the primary metric improves without unacceptable harm elsewhere

B. Replace the objective

C. Hide poor performance

D. Guarantee attribution accuracy

14. Lead qualification helps determine whether:

A. A prospect has a relevant need and plausible buying fit

B. A logo looks modern

C. A post gets likes

D. A product has a colour scheme

15. A prospect says ‘too expensive’. The best first response is to:

A. Discount immediately

B. End the conversation

C. Clarify the concern and comparison

D. Promise unlimited features

16. A business starts with 400 customers and loses 20. Churn is:

A. 2%

B. 5%

C. 10%

D. 20%

17. Cohort analysis tracks:

A. Groups sharing a starting event or period over time

B. All users without dates

C. Only paid media costs

D. One campaign slogan

18. Which is an example of substantiation?

A. Publishing a claim before checking it

B. Keeping reliable evidence for a factual claim before publication

C. Hiding limitations

D. Using a vague adjective

19. A paid influencer relationship should be:

A. Hidden in a long hashtag list

B. Clearly disclosed where the audience can notice it

C. Mentioned only after purchase

D. Left for viewers to guess

20. Which is a dark pattern?

A. A clear cancellation button

B. A plain-language consent choice

C. Hiding cancellation while making subscription easy

D. A transparent price summary

Answer key with explanations

1. B. The offer and message should start with a real customer need.

2. B. Brand is the accumulated perception and expectation.

3. B. Triggers move a customer from passive interest to action.

4. A. Targeting follows segmentation and selects attractive, reachable segments.

5. C. Earned media is attention gained without directly purchasing the placement.

6. B. 300 ÷ 15,000 × 100% = 2%.

7. B. A CTA gives a clear next action appropriate to the audience’s intent.

8. A. It aligns the team before producing the asset.

9. A. Flighting schedules activity in bursts rather than evenly all the time.

10. A. Dependencies determine sequence and can affect the critical path.

11. B. 120 ÷ 3,000 × 100% = 4%.

12. B. ROAS measures attributed revenue relative to advertising cost, not profit.

13. A. Examples include complaints, refunds, margin and unsubscribe rate.

14. A. Qualification assesses need, decision access, budget and timing.

15. C. Understanding the objection comes before proposing a response.

16. B. 20 ÷ 400 × 100% = 5%.

17. A. It reveals how the same group behaves over time.

18. B. Claims should be supported before they are published.

19. B. Clear disclosure allows audiences to understand the commercial relationship.

20. C. It manipulates users into choices or makes intended actions unnecessarily difficult.

Quick revision sheet

Term	Remember
Marketing mix	Product, price, place and promotion.
Positioning	The place an offer occupies relative to alternatives.
Brand	Customer associations and expectations.
Demand generation	Build awareness and interest that can become qualified demand.
Persona	Evidence-based representative customer profile.
Pain point / trigger	Ongoing frustration / event prompting active search.
STP	Segment the market, select target segments, position the offer.
Owned / paid / earned	Controlled channels / purchased reach / attention gained without direct payment.
CTR	Clicks ÷ impressions × 100%.
CPC / CPM	Spend ÷ clicks / spend ÷ impressions × 1,000.
Message hierarchy	Main benefit first, then supporting proof and detail.
CTA	Specific next action for the audience.
SMART objective	Specific, measurable, achievable, relevant, time-bound.
Flighting	Campaign activity concentrated into planned bursts.
Conversion rate	Conversions ÷ defined eligible audience × 100%.
Attribution	Assigns credit to touchpoints; does not prove causation.
ROAS	Attributed ad revenue ÷ ad spend; not profit.
Guardrail	Secondary metric that flags harmful side effects.
Sales pipeline	Stages with clear entry and exit criteria.
Qualification	Assess need, decision access, budget and timing.
Retention / churn	Customers retained / customers lost over a defined period.
Cohort	Group sharing a starting event or period, tracked over time.
Substantiation	Evidence supporting a factual claim before publication.
Consent / disclosure	Respect lawful data choices / make commercial relationships clear.
Dark pattern	Interface design that manipulates or obstructs informed choice.

Exam tip: Identify the decision being tested, select the concept that directly answers it, show calculation steps and units, and distinguish a leading indicator (such as clicks) from a business outcome (such as profitable sales or retained customers).